Chapter Forty-Six

The Debt of Hatred

Between 1229 and 1250, the Holy Roman Emperor Frederick II helps the pope establish the Inquisition and is then excommunicated and deposed

The Holy Roman Emperor Frederick II, dodging the rain of pig scraps hurled his way, had left Jerusalem. He arrived back in Italy in 1229, knowing from reports sent by his officials what he would find: the empire ready to break apart.

The Holy Roman Empire, held together only by the fiction of the Roman resurrection, was perpetually splintering. Germany had possessed its own strong national identity since the tenth century. The northern Italian cities, separated from the German duchies by the Alps, had already reassembled the twelfth-century Lombard League that had defied Frederick's grandfather. And Sicily, part of the empire only because Frederick II had inherited its crown from his mother Constance, was for all practical purposes a separate kingdom.

In Frederick's absence, Pope Gregory IX had taken revenge on the unrepentant excommunicate emperor by prying at the empire's cracks. He had given the deposed John of Brienne, the father of Frederick's dead wife, permission to attack Sicily, promised his support to the Lombard League, and gone even further: "The pope has . . . spread false news of our death, and